

STAGE THREE • JOB APPLICATION & INTERVIEW SKILLS

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Three • Job Application & Interview Skills

PURPOSE

Stage Three runs across three sessions: Building the Application, Interview Readiness, and Closing the Loop. Each gets one icebreaker built directly from that session's actual content, not a generic warm-up.

All three lean into genuine, often uncomfortable shared experience — rejection, bad interview questions, near-missed deadlines — and use humor and normalization to lower the emotional stakes before the real, more vulnerable prep work begins.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Three Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

The Application Graveyard

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask everyone to think of one job or internship they applied to and never heard back from, or got rejected from without explanation.
2. In pairs, share the listing's title and one honest guess at why it might not have worked out — could be the resume, the cover letter, the timing, or genuinely unknowable.
3. Full-group show of hands: how many people have at least three of these in their history? (Nearly everyone will.)

WHY THIS WORKS

Normalizes rejection as a numbers game before the group dives into building a genuinely better, more strategic system — exactly what FIRST C1 (Job Application Tracker) and C2 (Application Strategy) are about to formalize.

SESSION 2

Worst Interview Question Ever

TIME: 8 min

1. Quick round-robin: what's the most confusing, unfair, or bizarre interview question anyone in the room has ever been asked?
2. After 3–4 examples, ask: did anyone actually have a good answer ready, or did everyone improvise?
3. Bridge: “Today's about never being caught fully improvising again — building real, practiced answers before you need them.”

WHY THIS WORKS

Interview anxiety often comes from the fear of an unpredictable question. Naming a few examples out loud, and laughing about it together, takes some of the power out of that fear before real prep work begins.

SESSION 3

The Almost-Missed Deadline

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask: “Has anyone ever almost missed — or actually missed — an application deadline, a thank-you note window, or an offer response date?”
2. Quick show of hands, then one or two people share what happened.
3. Bridge into the session: “Today's about building the systems, calendars, and habits so today is the last time that almost happens.”

WHY THIS WORKS

This session covers the operational backbone of a job search: deadlines, follow-ups, and comparison systems. A quick, honest “who's been burned by this before” moment makes the case for why these unglamorous systems actually matter.